

A Practical Study of PHILIPPIANS

THE GOAL OF CHRISTIAN LIVING “Important Keys to Successful, Fulfilled Living”

Goal Number Seven – The Work of Christ – Philippians 2:25-30

Charles Jones says this about work:

(Life is Tremendous by Charles Jones)

Do you know what I like? I like to relax. I like to talk about work. I like vacations, conventions, commissions, salary increases, long luncheons. What do I get? Headaches, heartbreaks, turndowns. But do you know what I've been learning? If I don't get excited about what I don't like to do, I don't get much that I do like to be excited about. I've been learning that life is not doing what you like to do. Real life is doing what you ought to do. I've been learning that people who do what they like to do discover that what they thought they like to do, they don't like to do. But people who are learning to do what they don't like to do but ought to do, eventually discover that what they thought they didn't like to do, they really do like to do.

(source unknown)

Why is it that we feel that when we come into the body of Christ, it could all happen without any personal commitment and sacrifice on our part? That we're suddenly going to become spiritual giants or we can kind of just slip into it—just real simple and easy and not cost anything, or not being something that's going to really challenge us and cause us to have to be spent in situations.

The man that steps before us is the perfect individual from the standpoint of work, to be an example for each of us in the work that God has called us to do.

Now since we do not believe in the distinction between the sacred and secular, we're not going to say that this is for the minister and not for those who are out in the jungle trying to eke out a living.

We are all on sacred missions. It's just that yours is on a different field than someone else and we serve the Lord together in our endeavors. Work is a vital part of that.

The man that we get to talk about in these final verses of chapter 2 is Epaphroditus.

His name means CHARMING and probably anybody that met him would have gone away and said, "Boy, what an individual." He would certainly be a charming person because of his balanced priorities.

We've talked about:

the LOVE OF CHRIST,
the GLORY OF CHRIST,
the SUFFERING OF CHRIST,
the MIND OF CHRIST,
the DAY OF CHRIST, and
the THINGS OF CHRIST.

Now we turn to:

the WORK OF CHRIST in these verses.

The apostle Paul said in verse 5:

Philippians 2:5

Let this mind be in you which was also in Christ.

How does that mind manifest itself? **FOUR PICTURES** of it are:

1. JESUS emptied Himself, taking the form of a servant.

2. PAUL says, “if my life is poured as a drink offering, I joy and rejoice with you all.
3. It was TIMOTHY who is more concerned about the things of Christ than he is about his own things.
4. Now here’s EPAPHRODITUS—he is a man who is highly motivated. He must be a deeply intense individual who is consumed with the work that God has given him to do.

Let’s pick it up and look at it. It’s a rich section in these last verses.

v. 25 But I thought it necessary to send to you Epaphroditus, my brother and fellow-worker and fellow-soldier, but your apostle and minister to my need;

“But I thought it necessary to send to you Epaphroditus, my brother and fellow-worker and fellow-soldier, but your apostle and minister to my need;”

Many times we read a verse like that and we just pass over it and don’t stop and milk it for a minute.

There are FIVE WORDS here that describe this man and can put some flesh on him so we can begin to appreciate who he is. Let’s talk about those words a second.

First of all, he characterizes Epaphroditus as:

1. “MY BROTHER”—this is a term that we use in the body of Christ to refer to a brother or sister who has come to know Jesus.

John said:

John 1:12

But as many as received Him, to them gave He power to become the sons of God, even to them that believed on His name.

The minute we are born again by the Spirit we become brothers and sisters in God's family. So the very first thing we know about Epaphroditus is that somewhere, maybe it was during the time that Paul was there in Philippi—not all the names are recorded of what happens in these ministries as we're fully aware—that perhaps during that first visit when he and Syllas and Dr. Luke were there in the city, it was at that time that he came to know Jesus Christ as Savior. So he is a brother in the Lord.

The second thing we see about him is he is a:

2. “FELLOW WORKER”

Epaphroditus must have been in some kind of business endeavor in the city of Philippi. But this man either retired

and went into full-time Christian work or he organized his work schedule so that he could get off for a prolonged sabbatical to take this generous gift that had been collected by the Macedonian saints who were in an economic crisis.

Now we see the overtones of this to the retirement community?

Here's a man that doesn't say, "Hey look, I'm worn out and tired and I've done my thing for God while I've been doing my thing for man and so it's time for me to fiddle while Rome burns until it's time to go to the house."

Epaphroditus doesn't have that mentality. He is a "fellow worker."

When the opportunity came for somebody to take this money and go to Rome and minister, he's the first man to have his hand in the air and say, "I think I can rearrange my schedule and delegate my work so I can go."

He already has his work done, he's retired and he's free so he can go do it.

What did he do when he got to Rome? He got to Rome and first thing he met Paul. Paul just had to tell him about all these Pretorian guards that were becoming Christians. He was there in prison and he couldn't have a Bible study with them. So Epaphroditus rolled up his sleeves and started having Bible studies all over the city of Rome.

He probably called Rome and said, “Alright, I’m going to have to prolong my sabbatical because the ministry here is so exciting.” He just stays there.

When Paul writes his letter he says “fellow worker,” he really means it. This guy plugs some holes in the dam that Paul couldn’t plug because he was incarcerated. He was located in one spot and Epaphroditus could move around the city and minister to these wives and children of the guys that had come to know Christ sitting there in the cell.

We’ve had this kind of underground Christian movement going on, right there in the heart of the Roman Empire and it’s an exciting thing. Just like Timothy served with the apostle as a father served, as a child would serve to his father, so Epaphroditus is a “fellow worker.”

3. He’s a “FELLOW SOLDIER”

When we think of a soldier we think of running uphill into the wind. We think of tough things.

Ephesians 6:13

Use every piece of God’s armor to resist the enemy whenever he attacks. And when it is all over, you’ll still be standing up.

2 Timothy 2:3, 4

Take your share of suffering as a good soldier of Jesus Christ, just as I do. And as Christ's soldier, don't let yourself become tied up in worldly affairs, for then you cannot satisfy the one who enlisted you in his army.

There's one other guy in the scripture that's called a soldier. His name is ARISTARCHUS.

In the Bible whenever there was rumble, we'd find Aristarchus. If things were flying apart and there was a major crisis, Aristarchus was in the middle of it.

There must have been a whirlwind around him! He's a man from Macedonia and he could identify because he knew what it was to be persecuted for Christ. He was the one who was apprehended in the uproar in Ephesus and dragged into the coliseum. This didn't scare him. He continued faithfully serving the Lord.

It reminds us of that uprising in the Congo back in the 60's. The Simba's overran a bunch of our missionary people. They wrote a book called *Out of the Jaws of the Lion* that described it. There was a fantastic statement in the book. When the press and the government came to the missionaries and asked, "Do you want to get out of here before this uprising takes your life?" Do you know what they said? They said, "God called us to the Congo and I think we're willing to pay the price of serving as long as He allows us to serve." A bunch of them died after that decision.

That's a soldier. That's a person who's willing to say, "God's in this! He controls government. He turns the heart of the king. Things come from Him. Just because it's dangerous doesn't mean that we're supposed to get out of there."

Neither are we to be presumptions. That's natural to recognize.

Paul said, "to me, Epaphroditus is three things":

1. "he's my BROTHER,"
2. "he's my FELLOW WORKER," and
3. "he's my FELLOW SOLDIER."

To the Philippians he's TWO THINGS. Which gives us the other two that puts flesh on it. To you he was:

4. "your APOSTLE" and
5. "MINISTER to my need."

What does the term "apostle" mean?

It is "SENT ONE." He was sent by the Philippian congregation to the city of Rome to accomplish these purposes.

He is a "MINISTER." He's not only a missionary, he is a

minister—the team available as a servant to meet the apostle’s needs wherever they were.

What is the predominant characteristic of all four of these men in chapter 2?

The one word that would characterize all four of them is:

SERVANT.

Once the Bible says something four times, you have the key.

The secret to dynamic Christian living is not getting something. It’s learning how to creatively give what you have and to become involved as a servant in the lives of others.

That is the whole foundation for evangelism, for edification, for growth. It’s to learn how to move out of our world and serve someone else.

Mark 10:45

Jesus Christ came not to be served but to serve, and to give His life a ransom for many.

Richard Foster has written several books. His book *Celebration of Discipline* talks about that:

(Celebration of Discipline by Richard Foster)

Learn the lesson that if you are to do the work of a prophet, what you need not is a scepter but a hoe...As the cross is the sign of submission, so the towel is the sign of service.
(source unknown)

He goes on to describe what went on in the Upper Room. In his last statement is:

(Celebration of Discipline by Richard Foster)

When we choose to be a servant, we surrender the right to decide who and when we will service. We become available and vulnerable.
(source unknown)

In all four of these we see the very same thing.

We have a man who just wanted to be where God wanted him to be.

How'd you like to have those 5 things said about you?

What a compliment. Here's a man who was in a congregation and yet he ends up becoming:

1. a "brother,"
2. a "fellow worker,"
3. a "fellow soldier,"

4. an “apostle,” and
5. a “minister” or a servant.

v. 26 seeing that he was longing for all of you and was distressed because you heard that he was sick.

“seeing that he was longing for all of you and was distressed because you heard that he was sick.”

He got home sick. He was in a strange city and a strange place and he started having those feelings for home.

He was “distressed” because they didn’t have all the information. Why? As soon as the church hears that somebody’s sick well it’s a major crisis. The guy’s hanging on a slender thread to life and he just had an appendectomy or something like that. That’s the way word travels. He’s distressed that they don’t have all the information about him and his condition. He knew it was a concern for them.

Paul assures them—verse 27.

v. 27 For truly he was sick near death, but God had mercy upon him, not only upon him, but also upon me, in order that I might not have sorrow upon sorrow.

“For truly he was sick near death,”—we almost lost him—“but

God had mercy on him, not only upon him, but also on me, in order that I might not have sorrow upon sorrow.”

Here’s a man who had a burning zeal and a heart for God and he risked his life. We can see him working hour after hour, following up on contacts of Paul’s ministry. The ramifications of what took place in that prison cell as a literal underground revolution takes place with Paul having Epaphroditus. He threw himself into the work and as a result, he became physically ill.

His policy was probably the same as Paul’s in:

Philippians 1:20

According to my earnest longing and hope, that in nothing shall I be put to shame, but in all boldness as always, also now, Christ shall be glorified in my body, whether through life or through death.

How did Paul operate? How did he function as a minister?
How did he spend himself?

Listen to these verses to get an idea of what it is to pour yourself into work:

2 Corinthians 4:7-15

This priceless treasure we hold, so to speak, in a common earthenware jar, to show that the splendid power of it

belongs to God and not to us. We are handicapped on all sides, but we are never frustrated; we are puzzled but we're never in despair; we are persecuted but we never have to stand it alone; we may be knocked down but we are never knocked out. Every day we experience something of the death of the Lord Jesus so that we may also know the power of the life of Jesus in these bodies of ours. Yes, we who are living are always being exposed to death for Jesus' sake, so that the life of Jesus may be plainly seen in our mortal lives. We are always facing death but this means that you know more and more of life. Our faith is like that mentioned in the scripture. I believed, and therefore did I speak. For we too speak because we believe and we know for certain that he who raised the Lord Jesus from death shall also by Him raise us. We shall all stand together before Him.

What happened? He got real, real sick. he next statement is:

“God had mercy upon him...”

God intervened. Does God always intervene? No, God doesn't always intervene.

We don't know God's greater plan and schedule. In this situation, “God had mercy”—NEGATIVELY—not only on Epaphroditus in letting him to continue to live, but POSITIVELY—“also on me” Paul says.

Why?

“...in order that I might not have sorrow upon sorrow.”

God knows just how much we can take. God sometimes intervenes in mercy because He knows that and He answers our prayer to encourage us.

1 Corinthians 10:13

There's no testing or trial that's taken you but such is common to man. He will not allow you to be tested above that you are able.

It is “common to man.”

He is “faithful.”

He won't “allow it to go beyond capacity”:

“in order that I might not have sorrow upon sorrow.”

God knows our limitations.

One poet put it this way:

Mindful of our human frailty,
Is the God in whom we trust.
He whose years are everlasting,
He remembers we are dust.

Changeless is Jehovah's mercy,
Unto those who fear His name.
From eternity abiding
To eternity the same.
(source unknown)

He knows our human limitations.

1 Peter 5:7

Let Him have all your worries and cares, for He is always thinking about you and watching everything that concerns you.

He knows how far we've progressed in our walk with God. He knows just how much we can take.

Just like the engineer tests metal for stress before it's ever used and designed for a specific purpose, so here we know that God has a different stress level and He will certainly intervene and provide as necessary.

In this case, it would have been one more thing for Paul—a sorrow that would have been very difficult for him to have faced alone with all the other accumulated sufferings that he was enduring at this time. So God backed off and did a work in the life of Epaphroditus.

Do you believe God does that for us? If we don't, we don't know very much about a loving Father. We really don't quite

understand it yet, but He really understands just how much trouble and difficulty He can trust us with. And how much work He can do in our life.

If we think that life is overwhelming us right now, maybe we haven't gotten the perspective yet. Or the other possibility is, we haven't drawn upon the grace that is available if we just call upon Him for it. There's always grace equal to the trial.

His grace is always adequate.

v. 28 With haste therefore I sent him, in order that having seen him again you might be rejoicing and I also may be less anxious.

“With haste therefore I sent him, in order that having seen him again you might be rejoicing and I also may be less anxious.”

He says, “I sent him on back.”

We can get the feeling there that he didn't want to go. He got to feeling better and he said, “Paul, I'm ready to get back into the class ministry. I'm ready to get going!”

Paul says, “Epaphroditus, I've prayed about this and I really feel you've got a responsibility to the Philippian congregation. I think you better go home. I think it's going to be better right now for the sake of the ministry. You've gotten it all started but I think right now, for the sake of the folks back in

Philippi, the best part of wisdom is for you to go home.”

Epaphroditus probably didn’t like that at all.

Epaphroditus was so excited about every day waking up in Rome with a new ministry and new opportunities. God was taking care of that. He was consumed with it! Paul has to come along and say, “Ok, I feel it’s God’s time for you to go on back to Philippi.”

Notice he says:

“I also may be less anxious.”

Paul was on an anxiety kick.

v. 29 Receive him therefore in the Lord with all joy, and be holding such ones in honor;

“Receive him therefore in the Lord with all joy, and be holding such ones in honor;”

It’s in the PRESENT TENSE.

Be holding this kind of person in honor because of all that he has done for the cause of Christ here.

Treat him like a returning soldier from the field of battle. He’s represented you on the front lines with joyful, acceptance. Hold him in honor because one of these days he’s one of those

who's going to hear:

“well done thou good and faithful servant, enter into the joys I have prepared for thee.” (Matt. 25:23)

v. 30 because on account of the work of Christ he was near even to death, having risked his life in order that he might supply that which was lacking in your service to me.

“because”—here's the REASON and the GOAL—“on account of the work of Christ”—GOAL—“he was near even to death, having risked his life”—PURPOSE—“in order that he may supply that which was lacking in your service to me.”

The work was laid out and this man responded to the opportunity when he got there to do it, even to the point of risking his life.

He gambled with his life for the sake of the ministry.

It isn't right for believers to violate for the work of Christ, their rest, their exercise, their health habits, and say, “I'm burning out for God.”

We should be repulsed by that kind of botched-up priority by somebody who's sitting around trying to preserve their humanity for as long as they possibly can without ever being overstressed or stressed or stretched a bit.

We find those two extremes. Let's find that path of wisdom where we are disciplined in every area of our lives. Where we understand how the physical temple works and we try to cooperate with what we don't know when we hear it from those who do know, and to do it right.

Do we have a real burden for the work of Christ?

Matthew 9:36-38

Seeing the multitudes, he felt compassion for them because they were distressed and downcast like sheep without a shepherd. Then he said to his disciples, the harvest is plentiful, but the workers are few. Therefore, beseech the Lord of the harvest to send out workers into His harvest.

That's what we're talking about.

John 4:35-38

Don't say "there are yet four months and then comes the harvest." Behold, I say to you, lift up your eyes and look on the fields, they are white for harvest. Already he who reaps is receiving wages and is gathering fruit for life eternal, that he who sows and he who reaps may rejoice together. For in this case, the saying is true: "One sows and another reaps." I sent you to reap that for which you have not labored. Others have labored, and you have entered into their labor.

They said, “Hey Nehemiah, come down and meet with us.”
Listen to this guy:

Nehemiah 6:3

I sent messengers to them saying “I am doing a great work, and I cannot come down. Why should the work stop while I leave it and come down to you?”

Isaiah 6:8

Then I heard the voice of the Lord saying “Whom shall I send and who will go for us?” Then I said, “Here am I; send me.”

Jeremiah 8:20

For our harvest is past and the summer is ended, and we are not saved.

There are a lot of people to be touched! We aren't going to get it done the way we're doing it. The new agers are and the communists are! We can't assume that we can train a guy for the ministry and have him go out and be the great fisherman that stands behind the pulpit in the stained glass aquarium where he can HOOK A FEW!

That's the way we're doing it! The only way we're going to get it done is for us to get up and get on with the work! Let's come

in and help reap the harvest. We've got to go where they are. We're not going to get them to come to us.

The key to the whole thing is reaching out and demonstrating by the quality of our lives in an interpersonal relationship the Lord Jesus Christ.

We have opportunities to reach some people that don't know Jesus.

It's going to take some Epaphrodituses to organize their work schedule, to recognize the potential of retirement, and together we're going to make a mark for God.

Our work is going to be nothing but a whole bunch of spinning of wheels in the sand and sound-and-fury, signifying nothing if we don't get consumed with the things of Christ first.

We have to know what's on His heart! Cry over His world and be motivated with His love and for His glory, willing to suffer ANYTHING! With His mind, in view of the day of Christ, consumed with the things of Christ, reaching as many people as we possibly can.

God designed the body of Christ beautifully with each one of us having a spiritual gift or gifts. Now are you using those for evangelism?

Spiritual gifts were always given for the edification of others.

Our spiritual gift was designed for each of us to reach out EFFECTIVELY and to touch others. The work of Christ is being left undone while we're concerned about how we feel and what's happening with us within the body of Christ.

There has to be a balance somewhere because the work isn't being done! We're losing ground! The work isn't going to get done by hoping it does.

One poet put it this way:

Christ has no hands but our hands to do His work today.
He has no feet but our feet to lead men in the way.
He has no tongues but our tongues to tell men why He died.

He has no help but our help to bring them to His side.
We are the only Bibles the careless world will read.
We are the sinner's gospel; we are the scoffer's creed.
We are the Lord's sole message, given in word and deed.
What if the type is crooked? What if the print is blurred?
What if our hands are busy with other work than His?
What if our feet are walking where sin's allurements is?
Each time we fail our duty in country or in city,
We hinder God almighty and what an awful pity.

(source unknown)

Could we get a burden for the work of Christ?

John 9:4

I must work the works of Him that sent me, while it is day, for the night is coming when no man can work anymore.

Epaphroditus went and did the job.

Why did he risk his life?

Last phrase:

“...in order that he might supply that which was lacking in your service to me.”

There it is!

Instead of just Epaphroditus, there should have been a whole bunch of men who left Philippi to come and buy up this opportunity in the Roman Empire and Epaphroditus gets the job done! He has to risk his life because there aren't enough workers.

We have one man spilling his guts in front of the congregation. A bunch of people say, “Go for it man! We're behind you!” They're singing *Standing on the Promises* while they're sitting on the premises. That's it.

The work of God gets left undone.

Needless to say, this is a personal matter.

There's a lot of work that could be done if there were people who will mobilize and help the work to get done.

Here are the lessons we get out of these verses.

Lesson #1: Epaphroditus was a brother, a fellow worker, a fellow soldier, an apostle, and a minister. Are these things true of us?

Lesson #2: Epaphroditus was a willing layman, doing what he could for the cause of Christ.

Lesson #3: God knows just how much we can bear.

Lesson #4: Paul is sensitive to the Philippian's needs in this situation.

Lesson #5: Are you being spent in the service of our Lord?

Let's look at all these great men:

1. the Son of God—JESUS CHRIST—emptied Himself,
2. PAUL—willing to be poured out,
3. TIMOTHY—a servant, and
4. EPAPHRODITUS—a man who risked his life for the work of Christ.

1 Corinthians 15:58

So my dear brothers, since future victory is sure, be strong and steady, always doing the Lord's work, for you know that nothing you do for the Lord is ever wasted.

Father, help us to think through what it is that we ought to be doing if we're not doing all that we can for You now. May we discover things that are a part of Your heart by spending some qualified time with You. May it be a time of being still and knowing You're God and discovering the direction, the gifts and the abilities You've given us. Create within us an earnest desire to be creatively involved in a ministry of touching lives for Your sake. Father, may there be some good things here that will give birth simply because we're sensitive. We pray that our fogged vision will be clarified and that with that vision we'll move out, motivated by the love of Christ, to touch effectively the lives of others. In Jesus' name we pray. Amen.

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THE GOAL OF CHRISTIAN LIVING “Important Keys to Successful, Fulfilled Living”

GOAL NUMBER SEVEN – THE WORK OF CHRIST – PHILIPPIANS 2:25-30

KEY VERSE 2:30

v. 25 But I thought it necessary to send to you Epaphroditus, my brother and fellow-worker and fellow-soldier, but your apostle and minister to my need;

v. 26 seeing that he was longing for all of you and was distressed because you heard that he was sick.

v. 27 For truly he was sick near death, but God had mercy upon him, not only upon him, but also upon me, in order that I might not have sorrow upon sorrow.

v. 28 With haste therefore I sent him, in order that having seen him again you might be rejoicing and I also may be less anxious.

v. 29 Receive him therefore in the Lord with all joy, and be holding such ones in honor;

v. 30 because on account of the work of Christ he was near even to death, having risked his life in order that he might supply that which was lacking in your service to me.

NOTES

QUESTIONS:

1. Read Philippians 2:25-30 and in your own words pull out the main thought of this passage.

2. Who does Paul send back to Philippi?

3. What was wrong with Epaphroditus, according to verse 27?

4. How did he get this way, according to verse 30?

5. Do you think God has any work for you to do?

6. What service are you doing for Him now?

7. How should Epaphroditus be treated, according to verse 29?

8. How do you suppose their service was lacking?

9. Which verse in the study has meant the most to you?

10. What lesson have you learned from this study?

LESSONS FROM THE PASSAGE:

What are some of the lessons we can learn from this particular study?

LESSON #1: Epaphroditus was a brother, a fellow worker, a fellow soldier, an apostle, and a minister. Are these things true of us?

LESSON #2: Epaphroditus was a willing layman, doing what he could for the cause of Christ.

LESSON #3: God knows just how much we can bear.

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